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STUDENT HANDOUT

Source Detective

Grades 5–8 · ELA

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

ADMIT ONE

NAME	DATE	CLASS

Can you trust this source? Not everything you read or see is true! People have been creating fake images since the 1860s. Today, we'll learn a simple way to check if a source is trustworthy.

KEY IDEA

Just because something looks real doesn't mean it IS real. In the 1860s, photographers created fake "ghost" pictures and sold them to grieving families. Today, people use Photoshop and AI to create fake images and spread false information.

01 PART 1 — The CRAAP Test Checklist

Use this checklist to evaluate any source:

C Currency — Is it up to date?	When was this made? Is it recent enough for your topic?
R Relevance — Does it fit your needs?	Does it answer your question? Is it written for people your age?
A Authority — Who made it?	Is the author an expert? Can you find out who they are?
A Accuracy — Is it correct?	Can you find this same information somewhere else? Are there mistakes?
P Purpose — Why was it made?	Is it trying to inform you, sell you something, or make you feel a certain way?

02 PART 2 — Practice: Evaluate This Source

Your teacher will show you a source. Answer these questions:

What is the source? (website, article, image, video, etc.) _____

C — When was it created or last updated? _____

A — Who made it? What do you know about them? _____

P — Why was it made? (Circle one) To inform To persuade To sell To entertain

A — Can you find this same information somewhere else? Yes No I'm not sure

Where? _____

Is this source trustworthy? (Circle one) Yes Maybe No

Why did you choose that answer? _____

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

In the 1860s, a photographer named William Mumler created fake "ghost" pictures. He used a trick called double exposure to add blurry figures to photographs. He charged grieving families lots of money for photos of their dead relatives' "spirits."

These were primary sources (original photographs) — but they were still FAKE! Just because something is original doesn't mean it's true.

Visit the exhibition online to see how Victorians used optical tricks:

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

PART 3

03 Primary vs. Secondary Sources

Primary sources are original, firsthand accounts: a photograph, a diary, an interview.

Secondary sources analyze or interpret primary sources: a textbook, a documentary, an article.

Quick Check: Is a photograph of a historical event a primary or secondary source?

Primary Secondary

Is that photograph automatically trustworthy? Yes No

Why? _____

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Challenge: Teach your family the CRAAP test! The next time someone shares something online, ask: "Who made this? Why did they make it? Can we find the same information somewhere else?"